

PUNJAB ORIGIN

Tandoori Roti

Whole Wheat Bread, Tandoor-Charred
Punjab's Everyday Bread

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Tandoori Roti

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Tandoori Roti

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Daily Bread, Elevated

Where naan was historically a special-occasion bread, tandoori roti has always been closer to daily sustenance — a simple, unleavened whole wheat bread that Punjabi households and dhabas cook to order, charred over the intense heat of a clay tandoor. It's the same basic wheat dough used for everyday chapati, elevated by a cooking method that gives it a smoky char and a slightly crisp edge that a home tava can't quite replicate.

In villages across Punjab, communal tandoors were historically a fixture of daily life — families would bring their own kneaded dough to a shared neighborhood oven to be cooked fresh, a practice that still continues in some rural areas today. As Punjabi dhabas spread along highways and into cities, tandoori roti became a menu staple, valued as the lighter, healthier counterpart to naan.

This recipe uses a two-step technique — cooking on a tava first, then finishing directly over an open flame or under a hot broiler — that closely mimics the tandoor's dry, intense heat, giving you that same char and puff at home.

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

The everyday counterpart to naan, eaten far more frequently in Punjabi and North Indian households. Traditionally cooked to order at communal village tandoors, a practice still found in parts of rural Punjab. A dhaba staple, often served simply with a curry and a raw onion on the side. Considered a lighter, more health-conscious choice than naan, since it's unleavened and made purely from whole wheat.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	20m	15m	4
ACTIVE PREP	DOUGH REST	COOK TIME	SERVINGS (6 ROTIS)

Easy
DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Mixing bowl
- Rolling pin
- Heavy tava or cast-iron skillet
- Tongs, for the open-flame finishing step
- Basting brush

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Dough keeps refrigerated, wrapped in plastic, for up to 2 days — bring to room temperature before rolling. Cooked rotis are best fresh and hot, but keep wrapped in a cloth at room temperature for a few hours, or refrigerated for 2 days. Reheat briefly on a dry hot tava; tandoori roti doesn't freeze particularly well due to its lack of fat.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dough

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Whole wheat flour (atta)	2 cups	250 g	2 katori
Water, lukewarm	¾ cup	180 ml	¾ katori
Salt	½ tsp	3 g	to taste
Oil	1 tsp	5 ml	1 chammach
Ghee or butter, for basting	1 tbsp	15 g	1 chammach

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Whole wheat atta is specifically milled finer than Western whole wheat flour; if unavailable, a 50/50 blend of whole wheat and all-purpose flour is the closest substitute available at general grocery stores. This dough contains no yeast or leavening agent, so it's a naturally simple recipe with very few ingredients to source, making it one of the most accessible breads in this collection for cooks anywhere in the world.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Dough

01 MIX THE DOUGH

Combine the whole wheat flour and salt in a bowl. Add the oil and gradually mix in the warm water, bringing the mixture together into a shaggy dough.

02 KNEAD UNTIL SMOOTH

Knead for 6–8 minutes on a lightly floured surface until the dough is smooth, soft, and elastic.

> **Chef tip.** a firmer dough than naan's is ideal here — tandoori roti should hold its shape well when rolled thin.

03 REST THE DOUGH

Cover with a damp cloth and let rest for at least 20 minutes — this relaxes the gluten and makes the dough much easier to roll thin.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Dough, continued



COOKING CHECKPOINT

Properly rested dough should feel soft and pliable, stretching easily without springing back or tearing when rolled.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Rolling & Charring

04 DIVIDE AND ROLL

Divide the dough into 6 equal balls. Roll each into a round, about ¼ inch / 6 mm thick, dusting with flour as needed to prevent sticking.

05 COOK ON THE TAVA

Heat a tava until hot. Place the rolled roti on the dry surface and cook for about 1 minute, until small bubbles start to appear on the top.

06 CHAR OVER OPEN FLAME

Using tongs, transfer the roti directly over an open gas flame (or under a very hot broiler) for a few seconds per side, until it puffs up and develops light charring in spots.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Rolling & Charring, continued



Texture indicator. a properly cooked tandoori roti puffs up like a balloon — this steam pocket is what gives it a soft, layered interior.

07 BASTE AND SERVE

Brush lightly with ghee or butter immediately after cooking and serve hot.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Rolling & Charring, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Rolling the dough unevenly, with thick and thin patches, causes uneven puffing and charring. Aim for a consistent thickness across the whole round.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with any North Indian curry or dal, alongside a simple raw onion and green chili.
- A dhaba classic, often ordered by the stack alongside dal makhani or rajma.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served whole in a bread basket, char marks visible, brushed lightly with ghee.

Family Style

- A shared stack passed around the table, cooked to order so each roti is served fresh and hot.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Puff Right

- A well-rested dough is the single biggest factor in getting a clean, even puff — don't skip the resting step.
- Rolling evenly, with no thin spots, prevents the roti from tearing and losing its steam pocket over the flame.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Dough can be made a day ahead and refrigerated — bring to room temperature before rolling.
- Roll out all the rotis in advance, stacked between sheets of parchment, then cook them all in quick succession.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Dhaba cooks often lightly wet one side of the roti with water before it goes onto the tava, similar to the naan technique, which helps it puff more dramatically when transferred to the flame.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

110 kcal	3.5 g	20 g	2 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with fat used and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Butter Tandoori Roti	finished with an extra-generous butter baste.
Missi-Style Tandoori Roti	made with a besan and spice-enriched dough — see our dedicated Missi Roti recipe card.
Plain Phulka	the simplest home version, cooked entirely on the stovetop without the tandoor-style char.

Can I make this without an open flame?

Yes — a very hot broiler works as a substitute, watching closely as it puffs and chars quickly.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why didn't my roti puff up?

Usually insufficiently rested dough, uneven rolling, or a pan/flame that wasn't hot enough. All three should be addressed together for the best results.

Is tandoori roti healthier than naan?

Generally yes — it's unleavened, made from whole wheat rather than refined flour, and uses far less fat, making it a lighter daily bread choice.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Atta	finely milled whole wheat flour used for daily Indian breads.
Tandoor	a traditional clay oven capable of very high, dry heat.
Phulka	a simple stovetop roti, the everyday home version of this bread.
Chimta	long-handled tongs used to hold bread directly over an open flame.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Tandoori Roti

10m ACTIVE PREP	**20m** DOUGH REST
15m COOK TIME	**4** SERVINGS (6 ROTIS)
Easy DIFFICULTY	

DOUGH

Whole wheat flour	250 g
Water	180 ml
Salt	3 g
Oil	5 ml
Ghee or butter	15 g

METHOD

01 **Mix the dough.** Combine the whole wheat flour and salt in a bowl.

02 **Knead until smooth.** Knead for 6–8 minutes on a lightly floured surface until the dough is smooth, soft, and elastic.

03 **Rest the dough.** Cover with a damp cloth and let rest for at least 20 minutes — this relaxes the gluten and makes the dough much easier to roll thin.

04 **Divide and roll.** Divide the dough into 6 equal balls.

05 **Cook on the tava.** Heat a tava until hot.

06 **Char over open flame.** Using tongs, transfer the roti directly over an open gas flame (or under a very hot broiler) for a few seconds per side, until it puffs up and develops light charring in spots.

07 **Baste and serve.** Brush lightly with ghee or butter immediately after cooking and serve hot.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Whole wheat flour	250 g	☐ Salt	3 g
☐ Oil	5 ml	☐ Ghee or butter	15 g

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